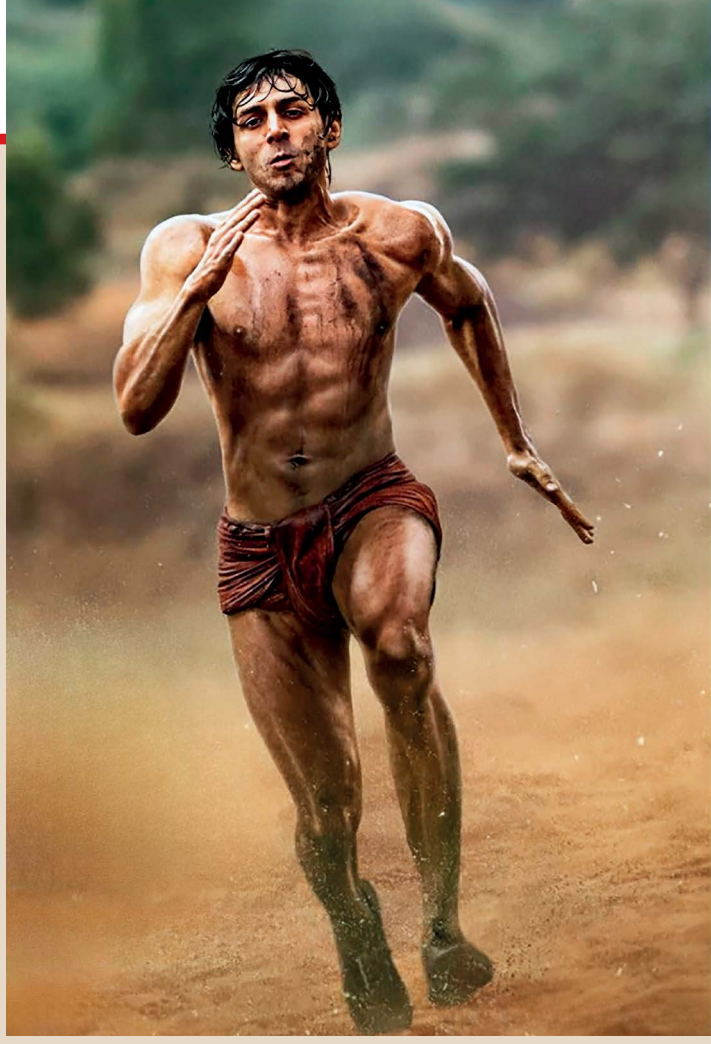


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Kartik Aaryan isn't the sort to play it safe. His films are proof enough. For every part two of a successful film (*Love Aaj Kal* and *Bhool Bhulaiyaa 2*) and bromance (*Pyaar Ka Punchnama* films and *Sonu Ke Titu Ki Sweety*), there's *Dhamaka* and *Freddy*, dramas where he's a complex anti-hero. Another addition to the mix of risky adventures was the recently released *Chandu Champion*, the Kabir Khan-directed biopic on Murlikant Petkar, India's first paralympic gold medallist.

The film doesn't have the usual tropes of his earlier films—a love interest, an earworm of a song with an exciting hook step which goes viral, or just plain-old laughs. Says Kartik, "That's the beauty of it. I really feel it is all about the story, the moment I heard it I was all in."

Enough has been written about the striking physique required to play the gifted Patil who excelled in multiple sports. Kartik had to learn to wrestle, box and swim, the latter like a paralympian no less, which in turn meant changing physiques. He also parted with his thick mop of hair.

Playing a real-life person for the first time in his 13-year career, the biggest challenge for Kartik was "to remove" his own image. It helped that little was known or documented about Petkar's sporting achievements or his fraught life. "After the first 10 minutes, you don't see me, you see the character," he says. Veteran actor Shabana Azmi would concur. In a recent Instagram post, she praised his portrayal. "He played it with an almost child-like determination with an extremely winsome smile which prevented him from projecting it as arrogance," she wrote.

In an industry where image-building is paramount, often needlessly so, Kartik has opted to not let his image be easily categorised. It's what convinced Kabir Khan that the actor had the right mindset to play Petkar. "I saw the boyish enthusiasm that Murlikant Petkar needed in Kartik," Khan said in an interview with India Today Online. There was also the hunger "to go into a zone which is going to be uncomfortable for him, to go through the journey of body transformation". It's a gamble that's not always paid dividends at the box office, but for the actor the reward lies in the effort and the challenge. "I'm trying my best to do something unique and exciting and entertain the audience in a different way from what I have done before," he said just a few days before the release of *Chandu Champion*.

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Playing Petkar has left a profound impact on him, particularly the athlete's single-minded determination to achieve his goal against all odds. "Every child should know about him as his story can inspire so many. It's the triumph of human spirit," says Kartik. "This is not just a sports film but the story of an Indian dream and one where our nation